

Prairie Smoke

Geum triflorum

Old Man's Whiskers · Three-flowered Avens



QUALITIES

A low evergreen rosette of fern-like compound leaves, 6 to 10 inches tall in flower, that hugs the ground year-round. In May, slender stems each bearing three nodding pink-purple urn-shaped flowers rise above the foliage. As the flowers age the petals fall and the styles elongate into long feathery plumes — pink, smoky, twisting — that give the plant its name. The plumes catch the light and the wind for weeks. By midsummer the seedheads dry and disperse, leaving the evergreen rosette behind.

CARE

Full sun, well-drained soil; ideal for sandy or rocky sites. Hates wet feet — site away from downspouts and low spots. Plant from 4-inch plug or quart container in spring or fall, 9 to 12 inches apart for groundcover. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Slow to spread but extremely long-lived once established — a clump can persist for decades. Avoid mulching directly over the rosette; the evergreen leaves want air.

HISTORY

Prairie smoke is one of the iconic remnant-prairie indicator species in Minnesota — finding a colony in a ditch or pasture is considered evidence of pre-settlement soil. The Blackfeet used a root decoction as eyewash and as a tea for stomach upset. The seed plumes were occasionally used for arrow fletching and as kindling. The name "old man's whiskers" appears across Indigenous and settler vocabularies for the same reason — the feathery plumes look exactly like grizzled hair.

REASON TO BE

Prairie smoke is the path-edge groundcover for which every native garden secretly hopes. It blooms before almost everything else in the prairie, drawing early queen bumblebees out of dormancy. Its evergreen winter presence keeps the bed from looking dead in March and October. The seedplumes are unforgettable — visiting neighbors stop in their tracks. Plant it where children can touch the plumes; that tactile encounter is how prairie ecology becomes real for a 6-year-old.